



Figure 9: GNOME 3 user system menu



Figure 10: Unity

at the bottom. This particular error is not fatal, but it keeps recurring, and diminishes one's confidence in the software. Notifications in GNOME 3 are unobtrusive, and can be pulled up at a later time, as shown in Figure 7. The Activities screen also allows you to search for applications and files (Figure 8).

Another deviation from the norm is the user menu in the top-right corner of the screen (Figure 9). The restart and shut-down options are now gone, and only 'Log Out' and 'Suspend' remain. To restart or power off the computer, either press and hold the **Alt** key while the menu is open, which replaces the 'Suspend' item with an option to power off or restart—or log out and then proceed to shut down from the login screen.

If you have more than one window open in GNOME 3, to switch between them, you either press **Alt+Tab** or open the *Activities* screen. The panel no longer has a task-bar to list open windows.

So it seems that GNOME 3 will take some time getting used to. Let's see how Natty fares.

Natty and Unity

The developers at Canonical have not adopted GNOME 3 for Natty, although they will for its successor, the Oneiric Ocelot. Ubuntu already had a netbook interface, which was somewhat similar to Natty's new interface, Unity—Canonical wanted to create a uniform look-and-feel across its desktop and netbook versions. Also,



Figure 11: Unity maximised window

the folks at Canonical were not entirely in favour of all the proposed changes in GNOME 3. Whatever be the reason, the decision to not use GNOME 3 in Natty has resulted in a much more stable environment than the one in Lovelock. So, what is Unity and what does it bring to the table?

Unity is just a shell running on top of GNOME. In Natty, therefore, you can select the Ubuntu Classic session from the login screen, if you want the default GNOME 2 interface instead of Unity. Figure 10 shows a customised Unity desktop on Natty. Like GNOME 3, Unity also uses a single top panel, but there is no notification area at the bottom. Notifications appear in the top-right portion of the screen, as in previous versions of Ubuntu. Additionally, the top panel now serves as an integrated menu bar for almost all applications, similar to the way the MacOS UI works. This provides maximum vertical screen space (Figure 11). However, the absence of a task-bar even here means that to switch between open windows, you either press **Alt+Tab** or use the launcher.

The launcher is a bar on the left side of the Unity screen that holds bookmarked applications and some lenses. Lenses are screens that show searchable lists of your applications, files, results on the Web, etc. However, unlike the GNOME 3 *Applications* list, you can view the categorised lists of your installed applications. Also, the applications lens shows random selections of the apps available for installation from Natty's configured software repositories, making it a useful place to discover new apps.

When you open a window, the launcher hides itself if the window needs its space, just as in the case of a maximised window. To get the launcher back, either hold your pointer at the left edge of the screen, or press and hold the OS (Windows) logo key on the keyboard. The latter action also causes the launcher to display numbers and letters on top of its icons. You can press a number or letter to open the corresponding window/application. Also, right-clicking an icon on the launcher opens a context menu with useful actions. You can remove any application from the launcher, and you can also drag